OFFICE OF THE CONVENER

African Global Queens Summit

Royal Collaboration for the Unity of Africa

Africa Branding: Reclaiming Our Identity, Reuniting Our People, and Restoring Our Place in the World

Delivered on behalf of Her Royal Majesty Queen Aruk II by Iquo Mary Erete McDowell, Queen Aruk III Designate, at Africa Week 2026

Excellencies, Royal Highnesses, distinguished traditional rulers, honoured guests, ladies and gentlemen,

I stand before you today on behalf of Her Royal Majesty Queen Aruk II, who regrets that a prior commitment prevents her from joining you in person. Her Majesty extends her warm greetings to the organisers and participants of Africa Week 2026 and her profound appreciation for this opportunity to reflect on the identity, dignity and destiny of our great continent.

Our subject is *Africa Branding*. But I invite us to look beyond the language of marketing, beyond logos, slogans and international campaigns, and confront a question of far greater consequence:

Who is Africa in the eyes of the world—and, perhaps more importantly, who is Africa in the eyes of her own children?

For Africa cannot command the world's respect if she is uncertain of her own worth. She cannot fully project her greatness if her people remain disconnected from the history, heritage and collective purpose that make them one.

Africa is not merely a geographical expression. She is the cradle of humanity, the home of ancient civilisations, the repository of profound knowledge, and the birthplace of cultures that have enriched the world. Yet, too often, Africa has been described through the vocabulary of others, her achievements obscured, her histories diminished and her immense promise overshadowed by narratives of deficiency.

The time has come for Africa not merely to improve her image, but to reclaim her authorship.

And in this historic undertaking, our African Queens occupy a place of singular significance.

Across our continent, and among our people scattered throughout the diaspora, the Queen represents something deeper than a crown. She represents continuity: the thread connecting ancestry to identity, history to destiny, and the homeland to generations who may have travelled far from its shores.

Consider the African child born in the Caribbean, the descendant of Africans raised in Europe, the family established in the Americas, or the young person who has never set foot on African soil but carries within their ancestry the memory of this continent.

Where do they turn to rediscover their roots? Where do they find the stories that connect them to their ancestors? Who welcomes them home—not as strangers seeking permission to belong, but as children returning to a mother whose embrace has never ceased to be theirs?

Africa must become more than the place from which our ancestors departed. She must become the home to which our descendants are welcomed.

In this vision, our Queens can serve as maternal figures of reconnection: bringing together histories, restoring broken cultural links, opening pathways to ancestral knowledge, and encouraging our diasporan brothers and sisters to return not only to visit, but to participate, invest, learn, contribute and build.

Their role is not to replace governments or political institutions. It is to help restore the cultural trust, human relationships and shared sense of belonging upon which lasting unity must be built.

For what is the value of an African brand that attracts the world's admiration but leaves Africa's own children feeling disconnected from her? What is the value of celebrating our heritage if the knowledge of our ancestors is lost to our grandchildren? And what can continental unity truly mean if we remain divided from our own histories?

Our brand must be built upon a living civilisation, not merely the memory of one.

This requires us to protect our indigenous languages, preserve our royal genealogies, safeguard traditional knowledge, honour our cultural custodians and ensure that Africa's heritage becomes a source of dignity, opportunity and sustainable prosperity.

It also requires us to recognise the place of women in traditional governance, to strengthen the participation of Queens and Princesses in community development, and to build partnerships that translate cultural wealth into educational, economic and social advancement.

Through initiatives such as the African Global Queens Summit, we seek to advance this vision: a vision in which traditional leadership contributes meaningfully to modern Africa, and in which cultural diplomacy becomes an instrument of unity, development and global engagement.

Excellencies, ladies and gentlemen, Africa's branding must ultimately answer three calls: **to reclaim our narrative, to reunite our people, and to restore our rightful place in the world.**

Let us tell our stories in our own voices. Let us welcome the diaspora not merely as visitors, but as partners in a shared future. Let us transform our heritage from a treasure admired at a distance into a living inheritance that educates, empowers and unites.

And let our Queens stand, with dignity and purpose, as bridges between generations, between the continent and its diaspora, and between the Africa we inherited and the Africa we are determined to build.

For Africa's greatest strength is not only what lies beneath her soil, what rises above her cities, or what is displayed in her museums. It is the enduring spirit of her people, the wisdom of her ancestors, and the promise of generations yet unborn.

Africa does not need to invent a greatness she does not possess. She must reclaim the greatness she has too often been persuaded to overlook.

Let us therefore build an African brand worthy of our ancestry, equal to our aspirations, and compelling enough to draw the world towards us—and our scattered children home.

We are Africa's memory. We are Africa's voice. We are Africa's future.

May we have the courage to reclaim our story, the wisdom to unite our people, and the vision to make Africa not only a continent the world recognises, but a civilisation the world respects.

Thank you, and long live Africa.

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